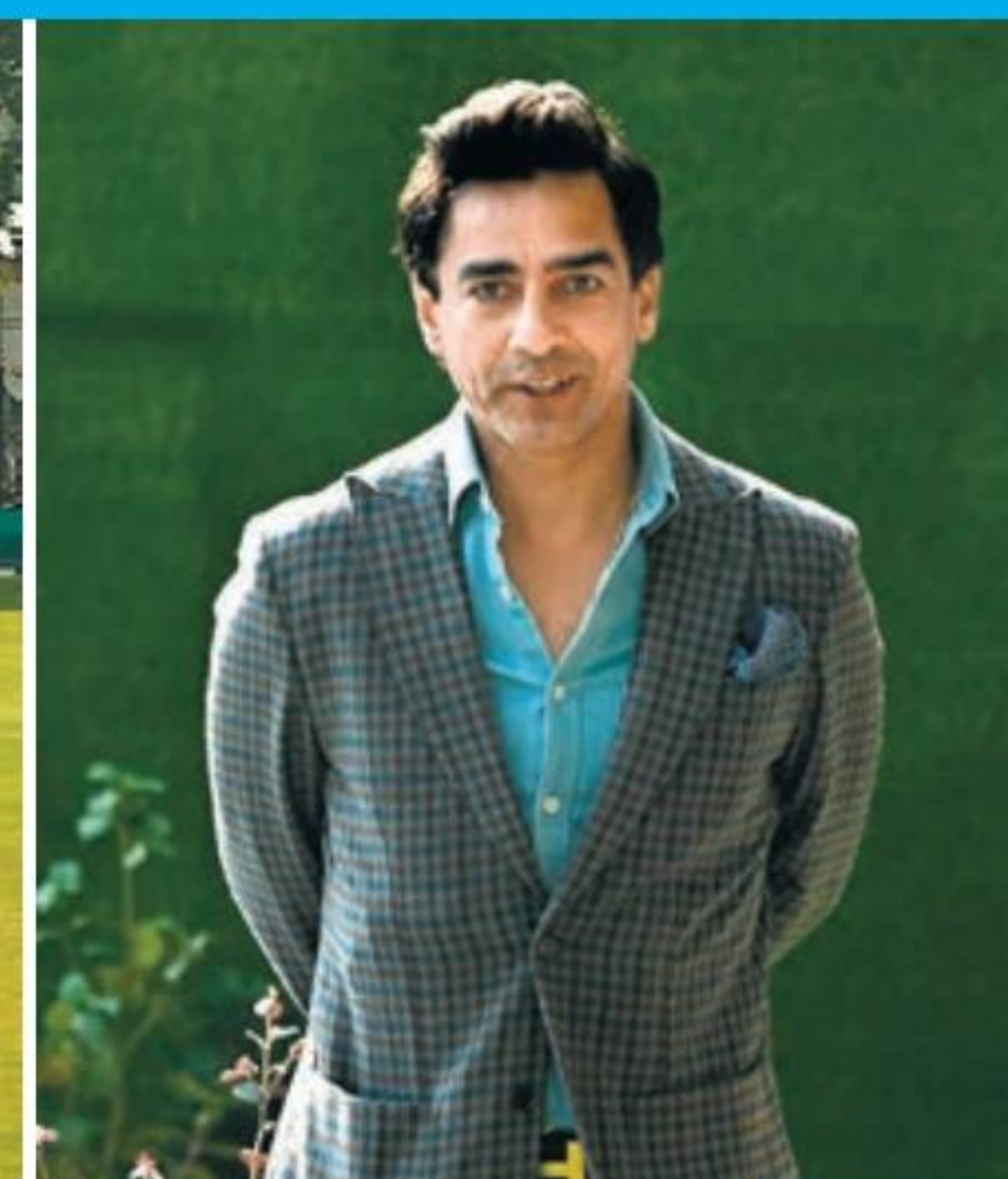




Ful'filling' experience: Between overs and aromas — Coimbatore's Valarmathi Mess feeds the Ranji trail.

PRASANNA VENKATESAN

Over fluffy idlis, bondas, omelettes and refreshing cups of filter coffee, he said he intended to show more of his personality, beyond cricket, in casual YouTube interviews. The Diary affirmed that this is exactly what viewers want and made a mental note to watch his recent interview with a popular YouTuber.

For lunch, the Diary visited Valarmathi Mess, known for its Kongu cuisine. Tamil Nadu cricketers Andre Siddarth (CSK) and C. V. Achyuth were spotted there. Siddarth smiled and waved; the Diary, in a food coma, sheepishly acknowledged.

Now, to the most intriguing part. On the final day, the two reporters and a TNCA liaison, someone well connected in cricket's media circles, found themselves deep in conversation.

That's when the Diary heard a remarkable nugget: a former India team official had once splurged Rs. 12 lakh in just an hour on apparel shopping in Chennai.

Prasanna Venkatesan

Hope in the valley

Beyond the heavy security guarding the entrance of the Sher-e-Kashmir Cricket Stadium in Srinagar, host to the clash between Jammu & Kashmir and Mumbai in the opening round of the 2025-26 Ranji Trophy, the Zabarwan mountain range and the chinar trees

Homecoming hope: In Srinagar's calm, cricket stirs again. For BCCI president Mithun Manhas, watching from the sidelines, it's both homecoming and mandate.

IMRAN NISSAR

provide a quaint, verdant backdrop to the venue situated in the posh neighbourhood of Sonwar Bagh.

It may be hard to believe, given the basic facilities, that this was once a venue which hosted two ODIs — between India and West Indies in 1983, and India and Australia in 1986. But geopolitical tensions and militant violence have meant that even First-Class matches have been sparse in recent decades. When it hosted two Ranji matches last year, it was after a six-year gap.

Majid Dhar, who played 37 First-Class matches for J&K and now oversees cricket in Kashmir, hopes for better days ahead. His optimism stems from Mithun Manhas's elevation to BCCI president in September.

Manhas had served as JKCA's Director of Cricket Operations after retiring in 2017 and was in attendance during the fixture.

"The facilities need to be upgraded. A good thing has happened for the JKCA; someone from our association is now representing the top position of the BCCI. We are hopeful things will improve in two to three years," Dhar said.

"This is the only First-Class ground in Srinagar. The season has started in October, which is why we are able to host matches here. When it gets colder, we host matches in Jammu."

Vivek Krishnan



Top performers after Round 1

Run-Scorers

1. Sanat Sangwan
Team: Delhi
Runs: 267
2. Ayush Loharuka
Team: Bihar
Runs: 226
3. Lalit Yadav
Team: Goa
Runs: 213

Wicket-Takers

1. Manav Suthar
Team: Rajasthan
Wickets: 11
2. Shreyas Gopal
Team: Karnataka
Wickets: 11
3. Sakib Hussain
Team: Bihar
Wickets: 10



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